from state to Union territory in 2019 also brought key changes to its domicile and land laws—in 2020, the official language list was expanded to five, with Kashmiri, Hindi, Dogri and English becoming part of it. This is the basis on which the opposition BJP is pillorying the Omar Abdullah government over the mandatory Urdu exam. Predictably, it has likened it to the sidelining of Jammu, where a majority speak Dogri, Pahari and Hindi. "We have five languages; this looks like the prioritisation of one region over the other," says Sat Sharma, president of the J&K BJP.

ON PROTEST MODE

The compulsory Urdu exam is nothing new. It was part of the last revenue department recruitment in 2021 as well, but there were no protests from the BJP then. That was probably because the J&K government was under the tight leash of the New Delhi-appointed Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha. This time around, Sat Sharma and Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma (also of the BJP) met Sinha on June 12 to demand the inclusion of other languages in the exam. In Jammu, the party's youth wing has organised protests.

The ruling National Conference, however, is unmoved. "Urdu is an intricate part of the region's cultural identity," Tanvir Sadiq, MLA and NC chief spokesperson, told INDIA TODAY. "It's the backbone of our governance, revenue, judiciary, land systems and belongs not only to Kashmir and Jammu regions but Ladakh as well." He called the BJP's objection "petty politics" aimed at creating a wedge between regions. The opposition Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) supports NC's stand on Urdu.

Urdu replaced Farsi as the official language of the erstwhile J&K princely state during Maharaja Pratap Singh's rule in 1889. In recent decades, the dominance of English in mainstream education has eroded its influence. Though many revenue records have been translated and digitised into English, Urdu is essential for comprehensive identification and quantification of land.

Meanwhile, resentment is brewing in another quarter. The high quantum of quotas in government jobs has angered Kashmiri youth. In 2015, there was 38 per cent quota in Naib Tehsildar recruitments; in 2025, it is a staggering 60 per cent. Under pressure from general category Kashmiris, a three-member government panel examining quotas tabled its report in the cabinet on June 18, which sent it to the state law department. Yet to be made public, disgruntled students are calling it a time-buying exercise. "It's binding on the law department to revert without delay," Sadiq says. "Justice will be served to all." ■

Takeaways

- **A recruitment notification for 75 Naib-Tehsildar posts in J&K requires a mandatory 50-mark Urdu test**
- **Pointing at Dogri and Hindi speakers in Jammu, BJP says it is unfair to many**

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT'S NOT EXACTLY A WIDENING FRONTIER, more a tactical pivot to an old staging post. For, Odisha has long been an operational base of Left-Wing Extremism (LWE)—especially its poverty-ridden hinterland, which is part of eastern-central India's tribal continuum. But mark the recent Maoist-related action in the state, and you can almost live-track the shifting map of the war against LWE. Take the latest one. In the early hours of June 13, the pre-dawn gunshots that lit up the forests were in Malkangiri district—deep down south in the state and smack bang in the Eastern Ghats.

Here, a special police team, acting on an intelligence input, accosted an armed Maoist unit near Sargiguda village, under Mathili police station. After a firefight, several insurgents managed to flee, but two senior operatives—Kesa Kawasi and Rakesh a.k.a. Sanu Kunjam—were apprehended. Both are 'area committee members' of the outlawed CPI (Maoist) and hail from Chhattisgarh's Bastar and Bijapur districts, respectively. Long active in the Andhra-Odisha Border (AOB) region, they carried a bounty of Rs 4 lakh each. A fortnight earlier, a similar operation had netted Kunjam Hidma—another Maoist figure of that rank and also a Chhattisgarh native—in Koraput district, immediately to the east.

A CONCERTED STRATEGY

These incidents are neither accidental nor isolated. They are part of a broader offensive by Odisha Police and central paramilitary forces to close off a key flank in the wider war against the Maoists. In recent months, intensified operations in neighbouring Chhattisgarh appear to have forced many Maoists to seek refuge in Odisha's forests, triggering a renewed push to intercept them before they can regroup. The idea is to get at the network of straggler Maoists still active in Odisha's remote tracts and close off any tactical sanctuary to fugitive insurgents.

Just days earlier, in the Charmal forests of Sambalpur district, also in the west, an operation was prompted by suspicions of Maoist movement across the border. Officials described it as a pre-emptive area domination